weakness. Alas, I was the machine gun of cricket.

So, after a decade or so in international cricket, I started concentrating on two things only: bowling and limited-overs cricket. Till my retirement, I was still doing the same, by the way. I've come to appreciate that I can bat well once in a blue moon, but most of the time, I can't. I'm comfortable knowing that, even if my critics are not.

Today, I'm happy with myself knowing that I started off as a bowler, have come of age as a bowler, will always be a bowler, but can bat from time to time and even deliver some match-winning performances. A lot of people may think that's defeatism, but it isn't. I was always a bowler. I could open or go one down in a 10-over tape-ball match on the street, but really, in the proper format, I signed up to be slotted as a bowler. Too bad nobody was listening until much later. That's when Bob Woolmer came into my life and everything changed, once again.

Just to be sure, I'm not saying I got pushed into batting. My maiden ODI ton was nothing short of a miracle. It sure felt like one, too. But after that game, with the increased attention and overnight stardom, there also came the burden of unrealistic expectations everywhere I went.

People used to say it all the time, and some of them still do: 'Wow! We love you, Afridi; we love your sixes; we love your shots; hit a six today.' It was almost as if I couldn't hit anything but sixes, as if I couldn't play the game any other way. That is what people began to expect from my batting. And I let it all get to me.

Maybe it was because I was young and naïve that all their comments went to my head. My excuse to myself was simple – this aggressive style of batting, this brutal power hitting, is what people like about me; this is all they expect from me. So, the pressure to play an innings filled with blinding hard knocks only mounted. It never relented, at least not in the early days.

There were pressures from elsewhere too. My coaches – there have been so many – always advised me to change my natural game. They wanted me to bat like them, to play the way they did in their playing days. That was unfair. It is this sort of coaching that was a disaster for me, personally. Had they accepted my innate style, my God-given talent, polished what I could do naturally with the bat and not stopped me from playing instinctive, aggressive shots, I believe I would have significantly improved my batting average. Instead, they tried to make me someone I was not.

So, yes, in those early years in the national side, I was under a lot of pressure – there were expectations from the press, the dressing-room, crowds egging me on as I walked to the crease, the coaches holding me back from playing the way I like to play … I think I became severely conflicted. On the one hand, there were the fans and their expectations; there were the people who believed in me and who made me believe that I had changed the game. On the other were these constrictive, conservative coaches who didn't see what I *could* do but only saw what I *should* do.

I didn't know how to play amidst such confusion. I honestly believe that I was damaged by all that pressure and didn't handle it well at all. At times, my performances became so dismal, I felt like a child who had been given a bat and sent in to face the world's greatest bowlers. For several years, I lost my focus and even my core strength: my confidence.

I'm not pinning all the blame on my coaches but had they given me some confidence, said, 'Hey, you bat the way you want … do your thing, I support you', I would have excelled a great deal. But after all these years, I can safely say that the only coach who gave me that kind of